Safety and the Obligation to Retract

eps2-proposed thesis (tested in ARA); bridge principle argued, not mechanically derived

Abstract

Disclosure: eps2-proposed thesis (tested in ARA); bridge principle argued, not mechanically derived. For the same earlier might-assertion and fixed context of use, an obligation on the speaker to retract at a later context of assessment occurs if and only if the original belief fails worldly-information safety as evaluated at that later context; in particular, safety preservation rules out the obligation. The target is that obligation, not actual retraction, permissible retraction, or another person's rejection. Sufficiency rests on a proposed bridge: later-assessed safety failure is a defect warranting disavowal of the original assertoric commitment. Necessity rests on a separate exhaustiveness assumption: no independent ground imposes the obligation while safety is preserved. Neither direction follows from a safety condition on knowledge, from a truth-based sufficient condition for retraction, or from rejection data. Safety failure is not treated as falsity, rejection is not treated as retraction, and a one-way retraction norm is not reversed to yield necessity. The biconditional is therefore defended conditionally: it holds for the fixed assertion and use context if the bridge and the exhaustiveness assumption are accepted.

1. Introduction

A speaker who has said that something might be the case can later face three different questions about that assertion: whether she retracts it, whether she may retract it, and whether she must. Only the third is at issue here. The thesis is that, for the same earlier might-assertion and fixed context of use, an obligation on the original speaker to retract at a later context of assessment occurs if and only if the original belief fails worldly-information safety as evaluated at that later context. In particular, safety preservation rules out an obligation to retract.

The thesis has two directions, and they need different support. Sufficiency needs a bridge from a condition on a belief to an obligation governing an assertion: later, assessment-relative failure of the original belief's worldly-information safety must count as a defect warranting the original speaker's disavowal of that assertion through retraction. Necessity needs something further, an exhaustiveness assumption on which no obligation arises when safety is preserved, because a sufficient trigger for an obligation does not by itself establish that the trigger is necessary. The biconditional is defended conditionally: if the bridge and the exhaustiveness assumption are accepted, the target follows for the fixed assertion and use context under consideration. That is a modest result. It does not derive the obligation from existing theories of knowledge or retraction. It states what would have to be accepted for safety to serve as the exact criterion, and it defends that statement against the objections closest to the cited literature.

The argument proceeds as follows. Section 2 fixes the test and its target. Section 3 reports the source commitments and what each leaves open. Section 4 states and defends the proposal, taking sufficiency and necessity in turn. Section 5 takes up four objections: that safety failure reduces to falsity, that the bridge merely transfers a knowledge condition, that independent grounds defeat necessity, and that rejection data tell against the proposal. Section 6 records the status of the claim and the bounds of the search behind it, and Section 7 concludes.

2. The test and its target

The test keeps the original might-assertion and its context of use fixed while varying the later context of assessment. Fixing the assertion and its use context isolates one question: whether the original speaker is obligated to retract that assertion at a later assessment. Holding the use context fixed keeps the target constant while assessment changes.

The outcome tested is correspondingly narrow. It is an obligation on the original speaker, not an actual retraction, not a permission to retract, and not another person's rejection of the claim. Knowledge loss, falsity, belief loss, actual retraction and rejection cannot be treated as interchangeable with that obligation without a separate argument, and no such argument is offered or assumed here.

The two directions call for distinct tests. One asks whether failure of safety, as evaluated at the later assessment, suffices for the obligation. The other asks whether such failure is necessary for it, so that preservation of safety excludes the obligation. Reversing a sufficient condition does not answer the second question. Neither direction follows merely from describing safety as relevant to knowledge, and so each is stated and assessed separately below.

3. Safety, worldly information and the retraction norm

Beddor and Goldstein formulate information-sensitive safety as a condition on knowledge: a belief amounts to knowledge only if, at every nearby world where the belief is held, the belief is true relative to the worldly information at that world (Beddor & Goldstein 2021, PDF pp. 5–15). They hold that every possible world determines a special body of information, either objective chance or some species of evidential probability, relevant to knowing epistemic-modal claims (Beddor & Goldstein 2021, PDF pp. 4–15). These are claims about knowledge and the information relevant to it. The condition as formulated is framed in terms of nearby worlds and worldly information (Beddor & Goldstein 2021, PDF pp. 5–15).

MacFarlane states a sufficient condition for required retraction in his Retraction Rule: an agent in a later context is required to retract an unretracted assertion that is not true as used at its original context and assessed from the later one (MacFarlane 2014, PDF pp. 122–123). He distinguishes this rule, which obliges retraction under certain conditions, from the rule governing the making of assertions, which forbids assertion under certain conditions (MacFarlane 2014, PDF pp. 122–123). In retracting an assertion, on his account, one disavows the assertoric commitment undertaken in the original

assertion (MacFarlane 2014, PDF pp. 122–123). Because a retraction is always the retraction of a specific speech act, he notes, two contexts are always relevant: the one in which the retraction takes place and the one in which the original act took place (MacFarlane 2014, PDF pp. 122–123). The worked example on those pages concerns taste rather than epistemic modals (MacFarlane 2014, PDF pp. 122–123). The application to epistemic modals appears in his 2011 chapter (PDF page 22, section 5.3) (MacFarlane 2014, PDF122–125 (=printed108–111), §§5.4–5.5; macfarlane2011 PDF22, §5.3).

MacFarlane is not opposed to the rejection approach, but he does not take it in that book: it is clearer that there is a speech act of retraction than that there is one of rejection, and he regards the retraction norm as all that is needed to understand the difference between relativism and all forms of contextualism (MacFarlane 2014, PDF p. 125). That choice keeps retraction, not rejection, at the centre of his normative account of the contrast.

Hawke describes Beddor and Goldstein's account as treating knowledge as a composite of belief, truth and a condition that renders the belief safe enough, and he considers a variant of it that drops the truth condition (Hawke 2024, PDF pp. 29–30). Within that variant he gives countermodels to two specified knowledge inferences and treats these failures as problematic features of the theory (Hawke 2024, PDF pp. 29–30). His discussion concerns the logic of knowledge ascription and does not state a retraction norm (Hawke 2024, PDF pp. 29–30).

Rudin reports empirical studies, focusing on one by Khoo, in which judgments of the truth of might-claims pull apart from judgments about whether to reject them: participants rated rejection responses highly while not agreeing that the might-claims were false (Rudin 2024, PDF pp. 7–9). Rudin takes such results to call for a theory of how truth conditions relate to update potential that predicts no biconditional relationship between assessment of truth and acceptance of an update proposal (Rudin 2024, PDF pp. 7–9).

These discussions concern distinct matters: a knowledge condition, truth at assessment, rejection, and the normative status of retraction. Transferring a knowledge condition to the normative status of an assertion does not establish a bridge from assessment-relative safety failure to a retraction obligation, because a further principle would have to connect them (Beddor & Goldstein 2021, PDF pp. 5–15). Hawke's knowledge-inference results do not establish a retraction norm (Hawke 2024, PDF pp. 29–30). MacFarlane's truth-based sufficient condition is not a safety-based biconditional; it establishes neither a safety-based trigger nor, still less, the converse of one (MacFarlane 2014, PDF pp. 122–123). Rejection by another speaker, as discussed by Rudin, is not by itself evidence of the original speaker's retrospective obligation (Rudin 2024, PDF pp. 7–9). The proposal therefore has to be assessed on its own terms.

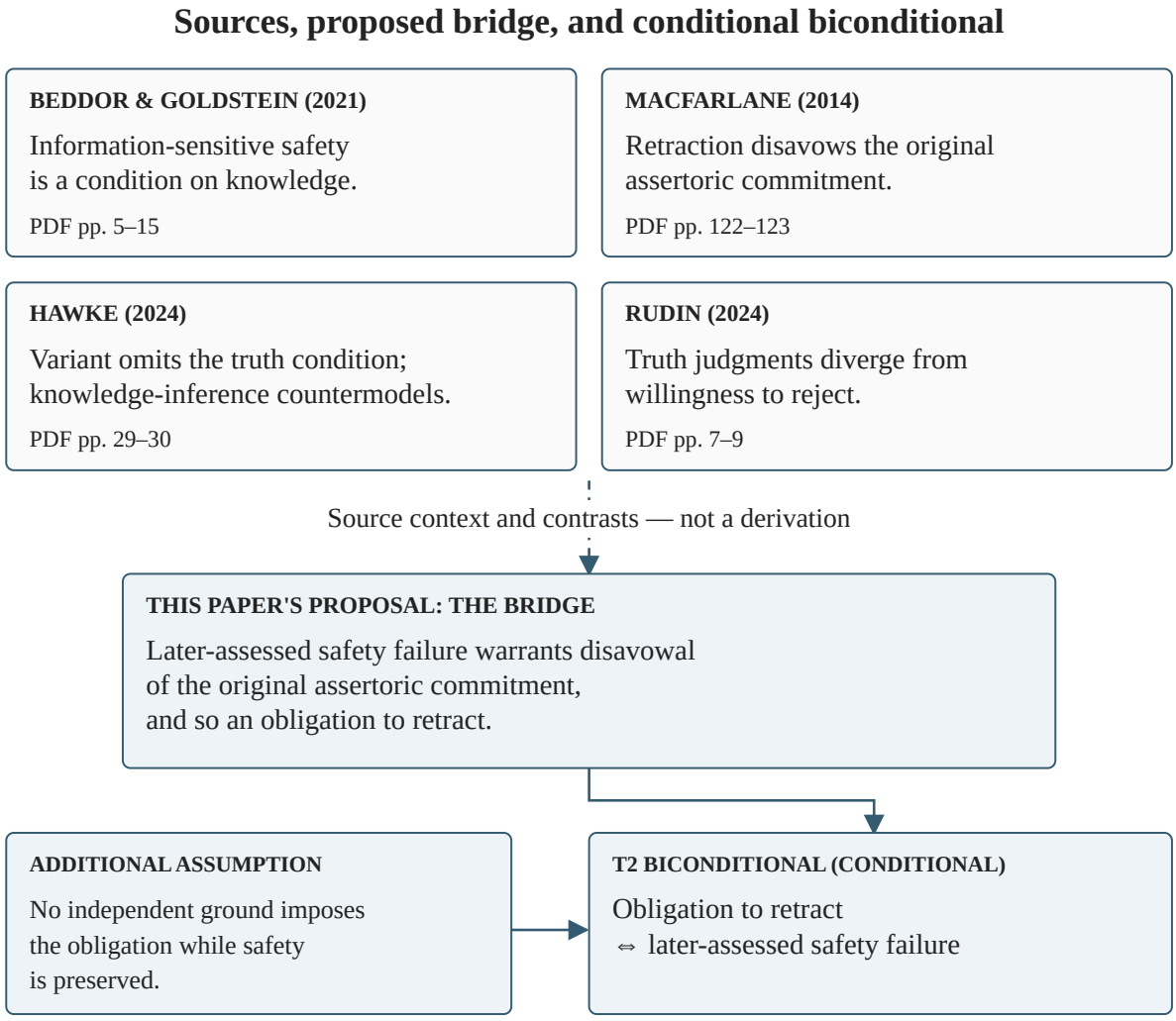


Figure 1. Sources, proposed bridge, and conditional biconditional. The dashed arrow groups source context and contrasts, not a derivation. The solid arrows locate the bridge and the separate exhaustiveness assumption used for the paper’s biconditional.

4. Proposal

The proposal is a norm restricted to one kind of case. For the same earlier might-assertion and fixed use context, obligatory retraction at a later assessment context occurs if and only if the original belief fails worldly-information safety as evaluated there; in particular, safety preservation rules out an obligation to retract . This principle is the paper's own. Evaluating safety at a later context of assessment, and connecting the result to an obligation, are parts of the proposal and not attributions to the sources reported above.

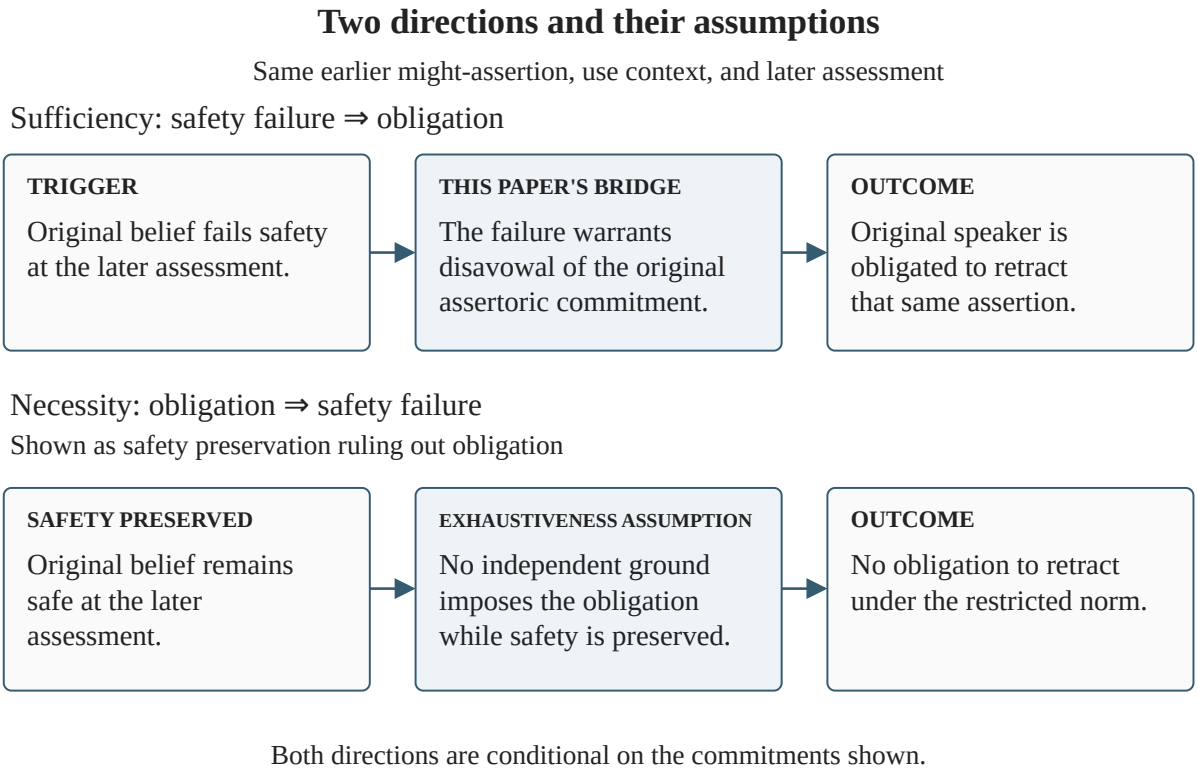


Figure 2. The two conditional directions for the same earlier assertion, use context, and later assessment. Sufficiency uses the paper’s proposed bridge. Necessity is shown in its safety-preservation form and requires the separate exhaustiveness assumption.

The sufficient direction runs as follows. For a fixed earlier might-assertion and context of use, later-assessed failure of the original belief's worldly-information safety counts, within the proposed norm, as a defect warranting disavowal of the original assertoric commitment, and so brings an obligation on the original speaker to retract that same assertion. The bridge is not mechanically derived from a condition on knowledge, because the conclusion concerns an assertion obligation.

The case for framing the bridge in terms of disavowal begins with what retraction does. MacFarlane characterizes the retraction of an assertion as disavowing the commitment it undertook, so that the speaker is no longer obliged to respond to challenges and others are no longer entitled to rely on the speaker's authority for its accuracy (MacFarlane 2014, PDF pp. 122–123). An obligation to retract is accordingly an obligation to withdraw from that commitment, and the bridge proposes that later-assessed safety failure is a defect of the kind that warrants this withdrawal. Trigger and outcome are thus linked by a normative rule, not by an identity between a belief condition and an assertion obligation. Accepting that the later safety failure warrants disavowal is what connects the specified condition to the obligation, and the direction stands or falls with that acceptance. MacFarlane also locates the fault in retraction cases in omission, in failing to retract something untrue (MacFarlane 2014, PDF pp. 122–123). The proposal shares that structural feature, though with a different condition: what it specifies is an obligation, and a speaker can be under it without having retracted.

The trigger must be read at the specified later assessment. The norm concerns whether the original belief fails worldly-information safety as evaluated there, not whether it failed safety at the time of assertion. Fixing the assertion, use context, later assessment and relevant outcome also prevents the sufficient direction from being mistaken for a claim about actual retraction or another speaker's response.

The claim made by this direction is limited in further ways. It connects the specified safety failure to the specified obligation, and it offers no general principle about what follows from every loss of safety. It does not settle whether the belief remains knowledge, whether it is false, whether the assertion is true, whether another person may reject it, or whether a retraction actually occurs. These are distinct questions from the proposed retraction obligation, and this direction needs no conclusion about them.

MacFarlane's Retraction Rule provides the closest comparison for the structure of the case, in which an earlier assertion is assessed from a later context (MacFarlane 2014, PDF pp. 122–123). The comparison clarifies the two-context structure of original use and later assessment. It does not establish that safety failure is sufficient for an obligation, because the conditions named by the two rules differ, and his truth-based condition cannot simply be replaced by safety failure without the proposed bridge. The safety-to-obligation connection remains a premise of the proposal, not a corollary of his rule.

The necessity direction is a separate commitment: when the belief remains safe under the specified assessment-relative criterion, the proposed norm imposes no obligation to retract. It does not follow from the claim that safety failure is sufficient for an obligation, because a sufficient trigger need not be the only trigger. Even if safety failure entails an obligation, an independent ground could also impose one while safety is preserved, and the converse would then fail.

The converse therefore depends on an exhaustiveness assumption, which the proposal makes explicit: the restricted norm is exhaustive, so no independent ground imposes an obligation to retract the same assertion while the original belief remains safe by the specified criterion. The claim that safety preservation rules out an obligation needs this assumption, since without it the possibility of an independent ground remains open. The assumption is not supplied by the safety condition, which concerns the original belief, or by the sufficiency direction, which connects safety failure to an obligation. It is an additional commitment of the norm, and its acceptability is tested by the third objection below.

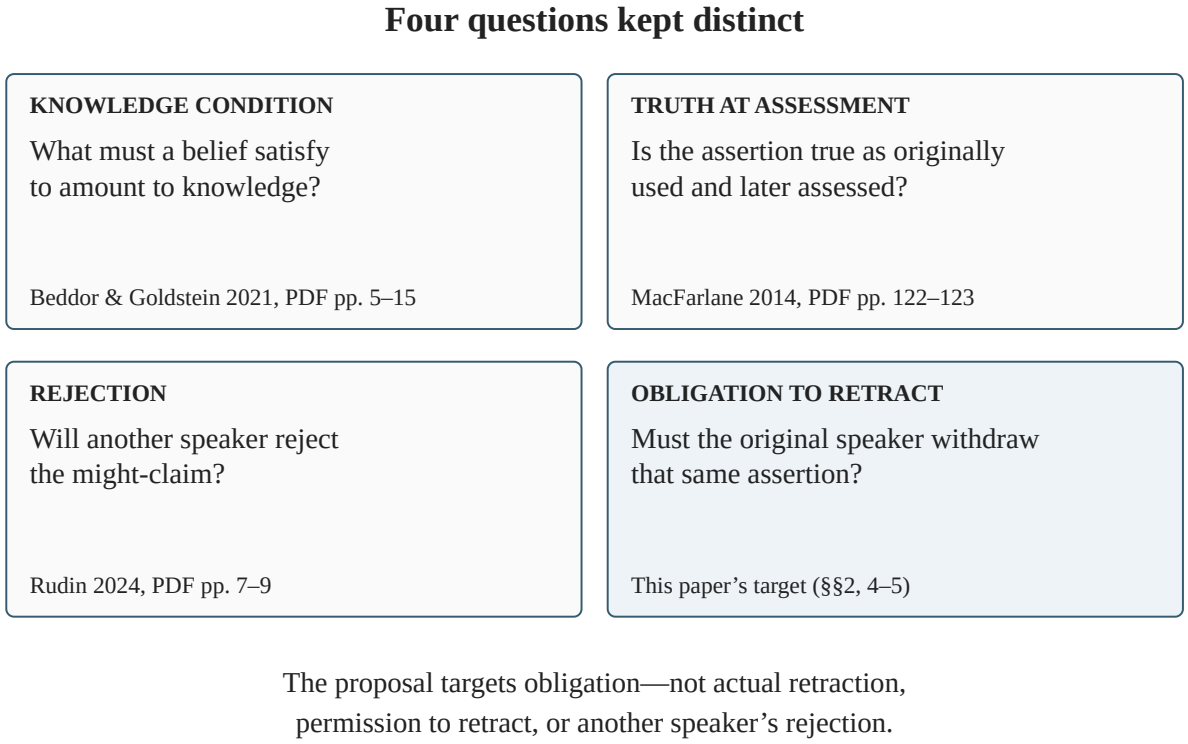


Figure 3. Four questions kept distinct. The highlighted question is the proposal’s target; the footer separates obligation from actual retraction, permission to retract, and another speaker’s rejection.

5. Objections and replies

The first objection targets the sufficient direction. If loss of safety implied falsity, MacFarlane's truth-based rule would already yield the obligation, and the bridge would be doing no independent work (MacFarlane 2014, PDF pp. 122–123). The proposal does not make that claim. Safety failure is the specified condition evaluated at the later assessment; falsity at that assessment is not built into the trigger, and the bridge does not require adding it as a second trigger. Nor does the proposal say that a belief's failure of safety entails that the assertion was false or makes it false. Treating safety as if it already included a truth condition would not supply the bridge either, since the two notions must remain distinct in assessing the claim. Hawke's variant, which removes the truth condition from a safety account, keeps the two apart without itself stating anything about retraction (Hawke 2024, PDF pp. 29–30). The consequence is that sufficiency cannot borrow the authority of the truth-based rule. It has to be accepted, if at all, as its own normative commitment.

The second objection is that the bridge merely transfers a condition on knowledge to an assertion, although Beddor and Goldstein's condition concerns what a belief needs in order to amount to knowledge (Beddor & Goldstein 2021, PDF pp. 5–15). Knowledge loss, the objection continues, does not by itself entail an obligation governing an assertion. The premise should be granted: a condition on knowledge cannot be transferred to such an obligation without a further principle connecting them. The bridge is that further principle, and it is proposed as such. It does not reason from the belief's ceasing to be knowledge to the obligation, since the sufficient direction leaves open whether the belief

remains knowledge. The objection does correctly locate one place at which the argument can be resisted: anyone who denies that later-assessed safety failure warrants disavowal has no reason from this paper to accept sufficiency.

The third objection targets necessity. A speaker might have some other reason to retract while safety is preserved. The challenging case is one in which an independent ground imposes the relevant obligation despite safety preservation. If an independent ground can impose the obligation within the target scope, the safety criterion alone does not establish the biconditional, and the claim that safety preservation rules out an obligation fails.

The closest source material comes from MacFarlane, who states that there is nothing inherently wrong with retracting an assertion one still thinks true, including when one does not want others to rely on one's word or does not want to take on the obligation of defending the assertion (MacFarlane 2014, PDF pp. 122–123). This discussion defeats any unrestricted claim about all permissible retractions, and it makes it important to keep permissibility distinct from obligation. That a speaker may retract an assertion despite still thinking it true does not, by itself, show that the speaker is required to retract it. The passage therefore does not refute the narrower proposal about obligatory retraction. It also does not support that proposal; it leaves the exhaustiveness assumption to be defended for the restricted norm.

The reply to the objection begins from the scope of the target, which is not every permissible retraction or every possible reason to retract. The claim concerns whether, for the same earlier might-assertion and fixed use context, the original speaker has an obligation to retract at the later assessment. A reason that makes retraction permissible or attractive is not, as such, a ground of that obligation. The converse is nonetheless defensible only if the relevant norm is restricted so that safety failure exhausts the grounds for that obligation. If that assumption is accepted, safety preservation excludes an obligation under the proposed norm; absent the assumption, that conclusion remains unsupported. The reply thus narrows the objection without dissolving it: a case of an independent ground imposing the obligation within the target scope would count against the biconditional.

A fourth challenge draws on rejection data. Participants in the study Rudin discusses were willing to reject might-claims that they did not judge to be false (Rudin 2024, PDF pp. 7–9). It might be thought that such willingness bears directly on when a might-assertion must be withdrawn. But an assessor's willingness to reject an assertion is not, by itself, evidence that its original speaker has a retrospective obligation to retract it. Rejection and retraction obligation are distinct outcomes, and MacFarlane's decision to rest his account on the retraction norm and not on a rejection approach gives no warrant for identifying them (MacFarlane 2014, PDF p. 125). The reported divergence does not establish either direction of the proposed biconditional. Nor can it substitute for the exhaustiveness assumption: willingness to reject does not show that safety preservation creates, or fails to create, an obligation on the original speaker. The data neither confirm nor refute the proposal, because they measure a different response by a different party.

The replies leave the two directions with different requirements. Sufficiency requires accepting the proposed bridge from a later-assessed safety failure to an obligation on the original speaker to retract that same assertion. Necessity additionally requires the exhaustiveness assumption that no independent ground imposes that obligation when safety is preserved, and neither the cited permission to retract nor reported willingness to reject supplies it.

6. Status and method note

The exact biconditional was not found within the stated 2018–2026 search, whose record reports no exact link between worldly-information safety and the retraction obligation (Literature-currency search 2026, 2018-01-01 through 2026-10-28). That result records only that such a link was not located (Literature-currency search 2026, 2018-01-01 through 2026-10-28). A failed search does not establish novelty or an open problem, and it establishes neither direction of the biconditional (Literature-currency search 2026, 2018-01-01 through 2026-10-28). The search window opens in 2018, so MacFarlane's 2014 book is background outside it (Literature-currency search 2026, 2018-01-01 through 2026-10-28). A focused bounded record covering 1 January 2018 through 28 October 2026, drawn from a sweep of literature on contextualism, relativism, expressivism, dynamic semantics, epistemic contradictions, probability operators, retraction and assessment sensitivity, returns a partial verdict: partial engagement is established in read texts, and no accessible source located there derives assessment-sensitive retrospective retraction from worldly-information safety (Literature-currency search 2026, 2018-01-01 through 2026-10-28).

The surrounding questions are partially anticipated by Beddor and Goldstein and by Dinges, neither of whom supplies the exact integration at issue (Literature-currency search 2026, 2018-01-01 through 2026-10-28). Beddor and Goldstein explain retraction as no longer standing by the update associated with an earlier modal assertion, which is a motivational story and not the formal fixed-use assessment rule (PDF page 2, section 1, introductory motivations) (Beddor & Goldstein 2021, PDF2, §1/introductory motivations). They reject a modal-knowledge ascription using assessor information, explicitly citing MacFarlane's 2014 book (PDF page 9, section 3.3, footnote 12) (Beddor & Goldstein 2021, PDF9, §3.3, footnote12). They treat knowledge as combining truth, belief and worldly-information safety across nearby worlds, and they state the safety condition separately from truth at an information index (PDF pages 17 and 23–24, sections 5.2–5.4) (Beddor & Goldstein 2021, PDF17,23–24, §§5.2–5.4, (30),(39)–(41)). They also allow that worldly information may be contextually selected and that contextual probability may model a conversational participant's or assessor's provisionally revised credences, but utterance-context selection and assessment-sensitive retraction are not identified or derived there (PDF pages 27–30, sections 6.2–6.3) (Beddor & Goldstein 2021, PDF27–30, §§6.2–6.3, especially28–29). Dinges explains retraction of knowledge ascriptions through stakes-dependent estimates of epistemic qualities, extendable to safety or reliability, and offers this consistently with denying relativism; it is a rival behavioural bridge and not the worldly-information semantics at issue here (PDF pages 3–6 and 10–11, section 4.3.1 and footnote 10) (Dinges 2021, PDF3–6 and10–11, §4.3.1 and footnote10). Holliday and Mandelkern cite

Beddor and Goldstein on modal knowledge but leave the pragmatics of truth, correctness, agreement and retraction to further development, compatible with multiple approaches (PDF pages 55 and 58, concluding discussion) (Holliday & Mandelkern 2024, PDF55 and58, concluding discussion).

The record names material access gaps, including older foundational chapters, complete books and recent empirical reviews (Literature-currency search 2026, 2018-01-01 through 2026-10-28). It is a ranked search of indexes and public sources, not an exhaustive review, and it lists the two strongest Hawke comparisons from 2024 as inaccessible (Literature-currency search 2026, 2018-01-01 through 2026-10-28). The only Hawke pages relied on here are the appendix pages cited in Section 3, and they are not taken to settle Hawke's treatment of retraction. The search's excluded-metadata log also lists Hawke's *Stable acceptance for mighty knowledge*, Kneer and Marsili's review of the empirical literature on assertion and retraction, Skovgaard-Olsen and Cantwell's *Norm conflicts and epistemic modals* and Xu's paper on probabilistic safety as metadata or abstract records only, so they are named as access gaps and not used as read texts or support (Literature-currency search 2026, 2018-01-01 through 2026-10-28). None of this search evidence bears on whether the bridge is correct.

7. Conclusion

For the same earlier might-assertion and fixed use context, obligatory retraction at a later assessment occurs if and only if the original belief fails worldly-information safety as evaluated there, and under the proposal's exhaustiveness assumption safety preservation rules out an obligation to retract. The claim concerns an obligation on the original speaker to retract that same assertion, not actual retraction, permission to retract, or another speaker's rejection. Its sufficiency direction depends on the proposed bridge from later-assessed safety failure to obligation, and its necessity direction additionally depends on the assumption that no independent ground imposes the obligation when safety is preserved. The comparison with the cited sources does not independently establish the conclusion, which stands or falls with those commitments.

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